

Blue Tit nests contain an average of nine eggs, although the females can lay many more. David Lack proposed that the clutch size is determined by the likely amount of available food.

“Clutch size increases with increasing latitude and day length because … a longer day enables the parents to find more food.”

David Lack

The “latitude trend”

Lack’s hypothesis also suggested an answer to another puzzle: why most bird species have bigger clutches at higher latitudes. On average, birds near the equator lay about half the number of eggs laid by the same species in the far north. This “latitude trend” could be explained by a greater availability of food during the long day-length of summer compared with the shorter day-length in the tropics.